SMALL BUSINESS BASICS · CANADA

Hiring Your First Employee

A step-by-step guide from job posting to first pay day

A plain-language guide for Canadian small-business owners

First edition · November 2026

Hiring Your First Employee — A step-by-step guide from job posting to first pay day

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Important. This guide is general information for Canadian small-business owners. It is not legal, tax, accounting, or financial advice, and it does not create a professional relationship of any kind. Rules, rates, forms, and software features change. Before you act, check the official source named in the guide and, where the stakes are real, talk to a qualified professional who knows your situation.

Nothing in this guide is legal, tax, or payroll advice. Payroll deductions are set by the Canada Revenue Agency, while employment standards, human rights, and workers' compensation rules are set mostly by each province, and all of them can change.

No result is promised. How useful any idea in this guide turns out to be depends on your business, your customers, your market, and how you apply it.

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Before you start

Hiring your first employee is a big step. Up to now, the business has been you: your hours, your skills, your bank account. The day someone else starts working for you, you take on new duties to that person and to the government. You also get help, which is the point.

What this guide covers. It walks you through the process in the order you will meet it: deciding whether you are ready, choosing between an employee and a contractor, writing a fair job posting, interviewing and checking references, making a written offer, setting up payroll with the Canada Revenue Agency (CRA), the provincial rules that apply to employees, and the first 90 days. Near the end you will find templates, worksheets, and a one-page checklist.

Who it is for. Canadian sole proprietors and small teams who have never had an employee: trades, cleaners, salons, consultants, landscapers, tutors, food trucks, small shops. The federal pieces (CRA payroll, T4 slips, the Record of Employment) apply across Canada. Employment standards, human rights, workers' compensation, and workplace safety are mostly provincial, so the guide points out where rules vary and where to check. Nova Scotia is used as the main example.

What it is not. This is general information, not legal, tax, accounting, or payroll advice. It cannot tell you exactly what applies to your business. Before you sign an employment agreement, classify a worker, or set up payroll, check the official source named in each chapter and, where the stakes are real, talk to an employment lawyer, an accountant, or a bookkeeper who does payroll. Rules and rates change every year, so wherever this guide mentions a rule, it also tells you where to confirm the current version.

How to use it. Read it once from start to finish, then use the checklist at the end to work through the steps. Each main chapter ends with a short "Key points" box. Print the worksheets and fill them in with a pencil the first time; your answers will change as you learn more. Keep everything you fill in, along with your notes and forms, in one folder for this hire.

Deciding to hire

The question is not only “do I have too much work?” It is “do I have enough steady work, enough cash, and enough time to manage someone?” Then comes a second question: do you need an employee at all, or would a contractor fit better?

Look at the work

For two or three weeks, keep a simple log of what you spend your time on. At the end of each day, jot down the tasks and roughly how long each took. Then sort the tasks into three groups: things **only you can do** (quoting, key client relationships, your specialist work); things **someone else could do with training** (routine jobs, prep and clean-up, scheduling, deliveries); and things that **do not need doing at all**.

The middle group is the job you might hire for. If it adds up to a few hours a week, a contractor, a part-time helper, or better tools might be enough. If it adds up to steady, predictable hours week after week, an employee starts to make sense.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a one-person landscaping business in Antigonish. Your log shows about 15 hours a week of loading, edging, raking, and hauling, and about 10 hours a week of quotes, invoices, and calls returned late at night. You are turning down jobs from May to October. The outdoor work is steady from spring to fall, so a seasonal employee might fit. The office work is a separate question; a bookkeeper or better software might handle part of it.

Count the full cost

An employee costs more than their hourly wage. On top of gross pay (pay before deductions), you will usually pay the employer share of Canada Pension Plan (CPP) contributions and Employment Insurance (EI) premiums; vacation pay and public holiday pay as your province requires; workers’ compensation premiums if your business is covered; payroll software or a bookkeeper’s time; and gear such as tools, uniforms, safety equipment, or a phone. Your own time spent hiring, training, and supervising is a cost too.

You do not need exact figures yet. You need a rough monthly number and an honest look at whether your income can carry it in slow months as well as busy ones. CRA’s Payroll Deductions Online Calculator (PDOC) shows the employer CPP and EI amounts for a sample pay. The hiring-readiness worksheet in the Templates chapter walks you through the sums.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> A made-up worked example: you plan to hire for 20 hours a week at $22.00 an hour, so weekly gross pay is $440.00. You run a sample pay through PDOC to see the employer CPP and EI, then add an estimate for vacation pay and gear. Say the total comes to about $520.00 a week. Over a year that is $27,040.00, or about $2,253.33 a month. If your slowest month cannot cover that after your other bills, you need a cash buffer, a seasonal arrangement, or fewer hours to start. (These numbers are invented. Use your own, and check your province's current minimum wage.)

Check your own time. A new employee needs training, feedback, and someone to ask questions. For the first few weeks you may get less done, not more. Can you block off time each week to train and check in? Have you written down how you do the main tasks, or is it all in your head? Is there a safe place to work, with the tools the job needs? If the honest answer is "not yet", that is fine. It is a list of things to fix before you post the job.

Employee or contractor?

Bringing someone in "on contract" can feel simpler than hiring, and sometimes it is exactly right. But the label you put on the arrangement does not decide what it is. CRA looks at the whole working relationship.

If someone is your **employee**, you must deduct CPP, EI, and income tax from their pay, pay the employer share of CPP and EI, remit to CRA, and issue a T4 slip. Provincial employment standards also apply. If someone is a **self-employed contractor**, they invoice you and handle their own taxes. If you treat a worker as a contractor and CRA later decides they were an employee, you can end up owing the deductions you should have taken, plus the employer share, and possibly penalties and interest.

No single factor decides it. CRA looks at these together:

Factor	Points toward employee	Points toward contractor
Control	You decide how, when, and where the work is done	The worker decides how to do the job and sets their own hours
Tools and equipment	You supply the tools, vehicle, and materials	The worker supplies and pays for their own
Chance of profit, risk of loss	Paid by the hour no matter what; no financial risk	Can earn more by working efficiently; can lose money on a job
Integration	The work is part of your regular business, done as part of your team	The worker runs their own business and serves other clients

EXAMPLE

Say you own a small cleaning company in Truro. You set the schedule, assign the houses, supply the vacuum and products, and pay by the hour, and the cleaner works only for you. Calling them a “contractor” on paper does not change much: the facts look like employment. Compare that with a carpet-cleaning firm you call in twice a year that brings its own van and machines, quotes per job, and has many other customers. That looks like a contractor. (Made-up example; the real answer depends on all the facts.)

If you cannot tell, you can ask CRA for a ruling on whether the worker is an employee for CPP and EI purposes. Search “CPP/EI ruling” on canada.ca/revenue-agency for how to request one, or talk it through with an accountant before the work begins. Do not choose “contractor” just to avoid payroll paperwork; if the relationship is really employment, the deductions are still owed.

If you do hire a contractor, get a written agreement that describes the result, the price, and who supplies what, and let the contractor control how the work is done. In Nova Scotia, ask for proof that they are in good standing with WCB Nova Scotia and check with WCB: if an uncovered contractor’s workers are hurt on your job, you may be responsible for their coverage. Other provinces have similar rules; check with your board.

KEY POINTS

- Log your time and find the tasks someone else could do with training.
- An employee costs more than their wage. Test the full cost against your slowest month.
- Make sure you have time to train and manage before you post the job.
- The working relationship decides employee or contractor: control, tools, chance of profit and risk of loss, and integration. If unsure, ask CRA for a CPP/EI ruling.

Finding and hiring the right person

A clear role makes every later step easier: the posting, the interview, the offer letter, and the training plan.

Define the role

Before you write the ad, write a one-page description for yourself. Give the job a plain title ("Landscaping helper", "Salon assistant") and one sentence on why it exists. List five to eight main duties, most important first. Note the hours and schedule, the location, the pay or pay range (at or above your province's current minimum wage), and any real physical demands.

Then split the skills into **must-have** and **nice-to-have**. Every must-have narrows your pool of applicants, so ask whether each one is truly needed to do the job or just a habit. A valid driver's licence is a fair requirement for a driving job; it may not be for a shop job. A requirement the job does not need can also screen people out unfairly.

Keep it fair: human rights basics

Human rights laws protect job applicants as well as employees. For a provincially regulated business, the law that applies is your province's or territory's human rights act. (Federally regulated businesses, such as banks and interprovincial transport, follow federal law.) These laws list protected grounds, such as race, religion, sex, age, disability, family status, and sexual orientation, among others. The exact list and the exceptions differ by province.

In general, do not ask about, or make hiring decisions based on, a protected ground unless the law allows an exception for a genuine job requirement. In practice:

- Describe the job and the skills, not the kind of person you picture doing it. Avoid words like "young and energetic", "recent graduate", "mature", or "handyman"; use "motivated", "able to learn quickly", or "helper".
- Ask about the ability to do the real tasks, not about health. "This job involves lifting boxes several times a day. Can you do that, with or without accommodation?" is about the job.
- Do not ask for a photo, date of birth, marital status, or plans to have children.
- Say that you will accommodate applicants who need it during the hiring process.

> **NOTE**
>
> Before you post, check your province's human rights commission. In Nova Scotia, that is the Nova Scotia Human Rights Commission, which you can find through novascotia.ca. This is general information, not legal advice.

Write and share the posting

A good posting is short, honest, and easy to scan: who you are, the job title and basics (hours, location, pay), what the person will do day to day, what they need to bring and what you will teach, and how to apply by when. Be honest about the hard parts. If the job means early starts, cold weather, or heavy lifting, say so; a clear picture helps the right people apply. Including the pay gives applicants what they need to decide. Your province may also have rules about what a job posting must include, so check your province's employment standards first.

Post where your likely applicants already look: your own website and social media, word of mouth, community boards, college and trade-school job boards, and online job sites. Canada's Job Bank (jobbank.gc.ca) is a free government job board. Job sites change their features and terms, so check each one's current rules. A job posting outline is in the Templates chapter.

Interview and check references

Decide ahead of time which core questions you will ask every candidate and what a good answer sounds like. Asking everyone the same questions makes it easier to compare fairly. The most useful questions ask people to describe what they have actually done: "Tell me about a time when you had to learn something new quickly" tells you more than "Are you a fast learner?" An interview question set is in the Templates chapter.

Keep notes during each interview and store them securely. Write down what the person said, not impressions of their appearance or background.

Watch out for small talk. Friendly questions like "Do you have kids?", "Where are you from originally?", or "When did you finish high school?" can touch protected grounds even when they are meant kindly. If you need to know something for a genuine job reason, ask about the requirement itself:

Instead of asking...	Ask...
Do you have children? Who looks after them?	This job includes some Saturdays. Are you available for that?
Do you have any health problems?	Can you perform the duties of this job, with or without accommodation?
Where were you born?	Are you legally entitled to work in Canada?

A short trial shift lets you see someone working. If you use one, treat it as work: pay for the time, keep the person safe and supervised, and check your province's employment standards on trial work before you set it up.

Check references. A reference check is a short call with a former supervisor or client. Ask the candidate for references and get their permission before you call anyone. Keep the call focused on the job: their duties, what they did well, where they needed support, how they took feedback, and

whether the reference would work with them again. If a former employer will only confirm dates and job title, that is not a sign of a problem by itself.

For some jobs, such as work with children or vulnerable people or in clients' homes, you may want a criminal record check or vulnerable sector check. Only ask for checks that relate to the job, tell the candidate in advance, get written consent, and keep the results private. Rules on what you can ask and how you can use the results vary by province, so check with your human rights commission or a lawyer first.

Make the offer in writing

Once you have chosen someone, call to make a verbal offer and confirm the basics (start date, pay, hours), then follow up with a written offer letter or employment agreement. Give the person a reasonable time to review it, and do not let them start work until it is signed; terms agreed after someone has started can be harder to enforce.

The written offer usually covers the job title and duties; start date; full-time, part-time, seasonal, or fixed term; pay rate, pay frequency, and method; hours and overtime; vacation and vacation pay; any benefits; probation, if you use one; how the employment can end, including notice; confidentiality, where relevant; and any conditions, such as a reference check or a valid driver's licence. An offer letter outline is in the Templates chapter.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> An employment agreement is a legal contract. Clauses about probation, termination, and notice can be unenforceable if they give the employee less than your province's employment standards require. Have an employment lawyer review your offer letter before you use it. One review can give you a template to reuse for later hires.

A **probation period** is a stretch at the start of employment when you both find out whether the job is a good fit. Each province's employment standards say how probation affects things like termination notice, and some protections apply from the first day no matter what. If you use one, put its length in writing, check what it does and does not change in your province, and give real feedback during it.

When the person signs, give them a copy, keep one in their file, and confirm the start time, where to go, and what to bring. Then let the other candidates know the position is filled.

KEY POINTS

- Write a one-page role description and keep must-haves to what the job truly needs.
- Describe the job, not the person, and do not ask about protected grounds. Check your province’s human rights commission.
- Ask every candidate the same core questions and keep written notes. Get permission before reference or background checks.
- Make the offer in writing before day one, and have an employment lawyer review it.

Payroll with the Canada Revenue Agency

Payroll is a series of clear steps, and CRA has detailed guides for each. This chapter is the map. Confirm each step on canada.ca/revenue-agency, and consider having a bookkeeper or accountant check your first few pay runs. This is general information, not tax advice.

If your business is in Quebec, payroll works differently in some ways: Quebec has its own pension plan (QPP) instead of CPP, Revenu Québec handles provincial payroll, and some forms differ. Check with Revenu Québec as well as CRA.

Before the first pay day

Open a payroll program account. Before your first pay day, you need a payroll program account (RP) with CRA. It is added to your Business Number (BN), the nine-digit number CRA gives your business. A payroll account number looks like 123456789 RP0001 (a made-up example). If you do not have a BN yet, you get one when you open your first program account. Search "payroll program account" on canada.ca/revenue-agency for the current ways to register.

Collect the employee's information. When the person starts, get their Social Insurance Number (SIN) and record it accurately. Have them complete two TD1 forms (Personal Tax Credits Returns): the federal TD1 and the TD1 for the province or territory where they report for work. You use the amounts on these forms to work out income tax. Get the current year's forms from canada.ca/revenue-agency, because they change each year, and ask for new ones if the employee's situation changes. Also collect their legal name, address, date of birth, start date, and banking details for direct deposit.

Every pay day and remitting

Each time you pay the employee, you deduct three things from gross pay:

1. **CPP contributions** (QPP in Quebec). Since 2024 there is also a second additional CPP contribution (CPP2) on earnings above the first earnings ceiling.
2. **EI premiums.**
3. **Income tax.**

You also pay an **employer share** of CPP (and CPP2 where it applies) and EI. That is your cost; it does not come out of the employee's pay. This guide does not give rates or ceilings because they change every year. Use PDOC or payroll software that is kept up to date: you enter the pay period, gross pay, province, and TD1 amounts, and it shows the deductions and the employer amounts. Taxable benefits, such as personal use of a company vehicle or a gift card, can change the deductions, so check CRA's guidance before you offer anything beyond wages.

EXAMPLE

A made-up example of one pay: your new employee at a small bakery in Wolfville works 60 hours over two weeks at $20.00 an hour, so gross pay is $1,200.00. You enter the details into PDOC. It shows the CPP, EI, and income tax to deduct, and the employer CPP and EI you owe on top. Net pay is gross pay minus the deductions. You save the PDOC result with your payroll records. (All figures are invented.)

Give the employee a **pay statement** (pay stub) each pay showing gross pay, each deduction, and net pay. Your province's employment standards may say what else it must include, such as hours worked and vacation pay.

Remitting. The amounts you deduct are not yours. You hold them in trust and send them to CRA, together with your employer share. This is called remitting. CRA assigns your account a remitting schedule, and your due dates depend on it; your account information and CRA's guides tell you which applies. CRA lists the ways you can pay.

WATCH OUT

Late or missed remittances can lead to penalties and interest. A separate bank account for payroll deductions can help you avoid spending them by accident. Put every remittance due date in your calendar.

Year end and when someone leaves

T4 slips. After each calendar year, issue a T4 slip to each employee showing their earnings and deductions, and file the T4 information return with CRA. Both are due by the last day of February following the calendar year. Confirm the deadline and filing options on canada.ca/revenue-agency.

Record of Employment. When an employee has an interruption of earnings (for example, they quit, are laid off or dismissed, or go on certain kinds of leave), you must issue a Record of Employment (ROE) through Service Canada. The ROE is used to decide whether the person qualifies for EI benefits. Search "Record of Employment" on canada.ca for current deadlines and online filing.

Running payroll and keeping records

You have three main options. **Do it yourself** with PDOC, tracking remittances and year-end slips in a spreadsheet: low cost, but it takes your time and mistakes are on you. **Use payroll software**, which calculates deductions, creates pay stubs, and can help with remittances, T4s, and sometimes ROEs: an ongoing cost, and you still check the setup and results. **Hire a bookkeeper or payroll service**: a higher cost, and you still supply accurate hours. At the time of writing, a range of payroll products serve Canadian small businesses; features and prices change, so compare

current versions and confirm they support your province. Whatever you choose, your business stays responsible for deductions and remittances. If someone else runs payroll, ask them to walk you through the first one.

A simple pay-day routine: confirm the hours worked (including overtime and holiday pay); calculate gross pay; work out deductions; pay net pay on time; give a pay statement; record the pay, deductions, and employer share in your books; and set aside the amount to remit.

Keep good records. Keep a file for each employee with the signed offer letter, SIN and TD1 forms, hours and pay records, vacation taken and paid, pay statements, remittance records, T4s and ROEs, training and safety records, and check-in notes. CRA generally requires you to keep books and records for six years from the end of the last tax year they relate to. Electronic records are acceptable if they meet CRA's rules and can be produced on request; check CRA's guidance on keeping records before you shred paper originals. Your province's employment standards may also require you to keep certain records for a set time.

KEY POINTS

- Open a payroll program account (RP) before your first pay day. Collect the SIN and both TD1 forms.
- Deduct CPP (and CPP2 where it applies), EI, and income tax, and add your employer share. Use PDOC or current software.
- Remit on the schedule CRA assigns. File T4s by the last day of February. Issue an ROE through Service Canada when earnings stop.
- Keep a complete file for each employee; CRA generally requires six years.

Provincial rules you need to know

CRA handles the federal payroll pieces. Most of the other rules that affect your employee come from your province or territory. If your business is federally regulated (for example, banking, inter-provincial trucking, or telecommunications), federal labour rules apply instead; otherwise, the provincial rules in this chapter are the ones to check.

Employment standards

Each province has an employment standards law that sets the minimum rules for employees. These usually cover minimum wage, hours of work and overtime, vacation time and vacation pay, public holidays, breaks, leaves of absence, notice of termination, and pay statements. You generally cannot agree with an employee to give them less than these minimums; a contract term that tries to is generally not enforceable.

In Nova Scotia, these rules are in the Labour Standards Code, on novascotia.ca. As one example, the general rule is that employees earn vacation pay of at least 4% of wages, with more after a certain number of years of service. Check the Labour Standards Code for the current rules and service thresholds.

Minimum wage changes regularly in every province, so this guide does not give a figure. Check your province's employment standards website before you set pay, and again whenever the province announces a change. Bookmark the page and review it at least once a year.

Workers' compensation

Workers' compensation is no-fault insurance for workplace injuries, run by a separate board in each province: for example, WCB Nova Scotia, WSIB in Ontario, WorkSafeNB in New Brunswick, and WorkSafeBC in British Columbia. Whether you must register, and when, depends on your province and your industry.

In Nova Scotia, coverage is generally mandatory for businesses in industries listed as mandatory once they have three or more workers at the same time, and you must register within 10 days of meeting those conditions. Businesses with two or fewer workers are generally not required to register but can apply for voluntary coverage. Owners are generally not covered automatically; personal coverage can be purchased. Confirm the current rules and your industry's status at wcb.ns.ca. A companion guide in this series covers WCB Nova Scotia in depth.

Health and safety

Every employer has duties to keep the workplace safe under the province's occupational health and safety law. In Nova Scotia, that is the Occupational Health and Safety Act, enforced by the provincial government (not WCB). Requirements, such as written safety policies or a safety com-

mittee, scale with the size of your workplace.

Even with one employee, it is good practice to walk through the workplace and note hazards before day one; train the employee on the safe way to do each task and record the training; provide the safety gear the job needs and show how to use it; explain how to report a hazard or injury and what to do in an emergency; and keep a stocked first aid kit. Check novascotia.ca or your province's workplace safety site for what applies to you.

Employee privacy

You will hold personal information about your employee: their SIN, address, date of birth, banking details, and sometimes health information for sick leave or accommodation. Collect only what you need, and store it securely. Keep paper files locked and digital files behind a password, limit who can see them, avoid sending a SIN or banking details by unsecured email or text, keep health information separate from the general file, and dispose of records securely once you no longer need to keep them.

Which privacy law applies to employee information depends on your province and type of business. The Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada (priv.gc.ca) has general guidance and can point you to your provincial commissioner.

KEY POINTS

- Most employment rules are provincial. In Nova Scotia, start with the Labour Standards Code on novascotia.ca.
- Check the current minimum wage before you set pay; do not rely on old figures.
- Workers' compensation is provincial. In Nova Scotia, check the three-worker rule and 10-day registration at wcb.ns.ca.
- Plan safety training before day one, and protect your employee's personal information.

The first day and the first 90 days

How you start someone off shapes how the whole job goes. Onboarding is the process of getting a new person settled, trained, and confident.

Before day one. Before the person starts, confirm the start time, place, parking, dress code, and what to bring. Get the workspace, tools, uniform, keys, and accounts ready. Print the paperwork: TD1 forms, a direct deposit form, an emergency contact form, and any policies to read and sign. Plan the first week (a sample plan is in the Templates chapter). If relevant, tell regular customers that someone new is joining.

Keep the first day itself simple and welcoming:

1. A proper welcome and a tour: parking, where to eat, washrooms, first aid kit, fire exits.
2. Paperwork: SIN, TD1 forms, banking details, emergency contact. Go through the signed offer letter together.
3. Safety training for the first tasks, with a record of what you covered.
4. An overview of the business: what you do, who your customers are, what you care about.
5. Some real, simple work, so they leave feeling useful.
6. A short check-in at the end: "How did today go? What questions do you have?"

The first week. Build skills in order from simple to complex. Show the task, do it together, watch them do it, then let them do it alone and check after. Give feedback the same day. Writing down how you do the most common tasks, even as rough bullet points, helps the new person learn faster and gives you something to update as the job grows.

Check-ins at 30, 60, and 90 days. Book three check-ins, at about 30, 60, and 90 days, in both calendars. At each one, talk about what is going well, what is harder than expected, one or two skills to work on next, and anything you could do differently as the owner. Write a short note afterwards and keep it in the employee's file. If there is a problem, raise it early, clearly, and kindly, and write down what you agreed. If you used a probation period, review progress before it ends and make a clear decision.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a small hair salon in Bridgewater and hire a salon assistant. At 30 days, the assistant is great with clients but slow at closing duties, so you agree on a written closing checklist. By 60 days, closing is on track and you start training on colour prep. At 90 days, you both agree the job is a good fit and confirm the next steps in writing. (Made-up example.)

A few simple policies. You do not need a thick handbook. A few pages can prevent misunderstandings: hours, breaks, and time-off requests; what to do if sick or late; phone and social media use at work; safety rules and injury reporting; pay days; confidentiality of customer information;

and how to raise a concern. Your province may require certain written policies, such as on workplace harassment or safety, depending on your workplace. Check your province's rules, and have a lawyer review any policy that affects discipline or termination.

KEY POINTS

- Prepare tools, paperwork, and a plan before the first day.
- Make the first day welcoming, include safety training, and end with a check-in.
- Train in steps: show, do together, watch, then let them work alone.
- Hold check-ins at about 30, 60, and 90 days and keep short written notes.

Templates and worksheets

Copy and adapt these. They are starting points, not legal documents.

Hiring-readiness worksheet

WORKSHEET

Tasks to hand off, hours per week, and steady or seasonal? _____

Weekly gross pay (wage x hours; check minimum wage): $_____

Employer CPP and EI per week (from PDOC): $_____

Vacation, holiday pay, workers' compensation, gear, software per week: $_____

Total monthly cost (weekly total x 52, divided by 12): $_____

Can my slowest month last year cover this? Buffer needed: $_____

Hours each week I can set aside to train and supervise: _____

Decision (hire now / hire later / contractor or other option): _____

Job posting outline

TEMPLATE

[Job title] at [Business name], [Town, Province]

About us: [Two or three sentences on what you do and who you serve.] **The job:** [Full-time / part-time / seasonal], [number] hours a week, [days and times], based at [location]. **Pay:** $[amount] per hour, paid [every two weeks].

What you will do: [Main duty]; [main duty]; [main duty].

What you need: [Must-haves only]. **We will train:** [skill]. **Expect:** [Honest note on hard parts.]

To apply: Email [address] by [Date]. We welcome all applicants. If you need an accommodation to apply, let us know.

Interview question set

TEMPLATE

Candidate: [Name] **Date:** [Date]

1. Tell me about your work so far and what interests you about this job.
2. Tell me about a time you had to learn something new quickly. How did you do it?
3. Walk me through how you would [real task from the job].
4. Describe a time a customer or co-worker was unhappy. What happened?
5. Tell me about a mistake you made at work and what you did next.
6. What kind of supervision and feedback helps you do your best work?
7. This job involves [weekend work / lifting / outdoor work]. Can you do that, with or without accommodation?
8. Are you legally entitled to work in Canada? When could you start?
9. What questions do you have for me?

Reference questions (with the candidate's permission): How do you know [Name]? What were their main duties? What did they do especially well? Where did they need support? How did they take feedback? Would you work with them again?

Notes (what was said, not impressions): _____

New-hire paperwork checklist

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Payroll program account (RP) open with CRA before the first pay day
- [ ] Signed offer letter or employment agreement on file
- [ ] Social Insurance Number recorded
- [ ] Federal and provincial or territorial TD1 forms completed (current year)
- [ ] Direct deposit details and emergency contact
- [ ] Workers' compensation rules checked for your province (in Nova Scotia, wcb.ns.ca)
- [ ] Safety orientation recorded; workplace policies given and signed
- [ ] Pay schedule, first pay day, and remittance due dates in your calendar
- [ ] Secure place set up for the employee file

Offer letter outline

WATCH OUT

A starting point only. Have an employment lawyer in your province review your offer letter before you use it, especially the probation, termination, and notice wording.

TEMPLATE

[Business name], [Address] — [Date]

Dear [Name],

We are pleased to offer you the position of **[job title]** with [Business name], starting [Date]. This letter sets out the terms of your employment.

Type: [Full-time / part-time / seasonal / fixed term ending [Date]]. **Duties:** [Short description or "see attached role description"].

Hours: [Regular hours and days]. Overtime is paid in line with [Province]'s employment standards.

Pay: $[amount] per [hour / year], paid [every two weeks] by [direct deposit].

Vacation: [Time and vacation pay, at least what [Province]'s employment standards require.] **Benefits:** [If any.]

Probation: [Length and what it means. Lawyer to review.] **Ending employment:** [Notice terms. Lawyer to review.]

Policies and conditions: You agree to follow our workplace policies, including [safety policy]. This offer depends on [satisfactory reference checks / valid driver's licence].

Please sign below to accept by [Date]. Sincerely, [Your name], [Title]

Accepted by: _____ Date: _____

First-week plan

TEMPLATE

Employee: [Name] **Start date:** [Date]

Day 1: Welcome and tour. Paperwork (SIN, TD1 forms, banking, emergency contact). Safety orientation. Overview of the business. One simple real task. End-of-day check-in.

Day 2: Review day 1. Learn [task A]: watch, then do together.

Day 3: Do [task A] with supervision. Learn [task B]: watch, then do together.

Day 4: Do [task A] alone and check after. Do [task B] with supervision. Introduce [customers / tools / software].

Day 5: Practise [tasks A and B]. Review the week: what went well, what is still confusing, plan for week 2.

Check-ins booked: 30 days [Date], 60 days [Date], 90 days [Date]

Checklist

Use this page to track the whole process. Not every step applies to every business, and the rules depend on your province. This is general information, not legal or tax advice.

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Log your time and complete the hiring-readiness worksheet
- [ ] Decide employee or contractor; ask CRA or an accountant if unsure
- [ ] Write a one-page role description
- [ ] Check your province's minimum wage, employment standards, and human rights guidance
- [ ] Write and post the job ad, with pay and an accommodation note
- [ ] Prepare a standard set of interview questions
- [ ] Interview, take notes, and get permission before reference checks
- [ ] Make a written offer, reviewed by an employment lawyer
- [ ] Open a CRA payroll program account (RP) before the first pay day
- [ ] Choose how you will run payroll: yourself, software, or a bookkeeper
- [ ] Check workers' compensation rules for your province and industry
- [ ] Prepare the workspace, safety gear, and first-week plan
- [ ] Collect SIN, both TD1 forms, and banking details on day one
- [ ] Do a safety orientation and record it
- [ ] Run each pay with PDOC or software and give a pay statement
- [ ] Remit deductions and employer share on CRA's schedule
- [ ] Hold check-ins at about 30, 60, and 90 days
- [ ] Keep a secure file for each employee; keep records for six years
- [ ] Issue T4s and file the T4 return by the last day of February
- [ ] Issue an ROE through Service Canada whenever earnings are interrupted

Where to learn more

These are official sources. Websites change, so start at the homepage and use the search box, and confirm current rules and deadlines before you act.

Federal

- **Canada Revenue Agency** (canada.ca/revenue-agency): payroll accounts, TD1 forms, PDOC, remitting, T4 slips, CPP/EI rulings, and keeping records.
- **Service Canada** (canada.ca): Records of Employment and Social Insurance Numbers.
- **Job Bank** (jobbank.gc.ca): the Government of Canada's job board.
- **Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada** (priv.gc.ca): privacy guidance.

Provincial (Nova Scotia examples)

- **Labour Standards Code** (novascotia.ca): minimum wage, vacation pay, holidays, hours, and termination notice.
- **Nova Scotia Human Rights Commission** (find it through novascotia.ca): protected grounds and fair hiring.
- **Occupational health and safety** (novascotia.ca): employer safety duties.
- **WCB Nova Scotia** (wcb.ns.ca): registration, premiums, and injury reporting.

Outside Nova Scotia, search for your province's employment standards, human rights commission, workplace safety, and workers' compensation board. In Quebec, also check Revenu Québec for payroll.

Talk to a professional

- **An employment lawyer** can review your offer letter, agreement, and policies, and advise on probation, termination, and human rights questions.
- **An accountant** can help with employee-or-contractor questions, taxable benefits, and how payroll fits your overall tax picture.
- **A bookkeeper who does payroll** can set up and run payroll, or check your first few pay runs.

Work through one step at a time, keep good records, and ask for help where the stakes are high.